For Indian spymasters, countering China, which has forged a deep nexus with Pakistan, is a formidable task. It is obvious that countries must spy on each other to keep a step ahead. China has mastered that art. But in the last two decades, the R&AW has devoted considerable resources to tackle Chinese moves in the grey world. The agency believes China is terrified by India's growing clout in Asia and always willing to engineer clumsy provocations, like the one in the Maldives in 2012, when it covertly supported the ouster of President Mohamed Nasheed, widely known for his pro-India stand.

Chinese expansionist designs now ensure that India will be riddled with more spies. In January 2018, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and some senior intelligence officials met to discuss efforts to counter Chinese and Pakistani intelligence in India. The prime minister was told that Pakistani spies were increasing infiltration to monitor India's activities in nuclear, space and missile technology and money was being pumped in through recruits to obtain classified documents. An intelligence officer talked about Pakistan-backed espionage modules which were mostly concentrated in the border districts of Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat and West Bengal. There were increasing cases of honey trapping and the ISI was also using many Indian agents on its payrolls to lure disgruntled elements of the establishment through the Pakistan mission in India. The intelligence officer asserted that the ISI was compromising government officials posted in Indian embassies around the world by exploiting their weaknesses.

A decision was taken to keep round-the-clock surveillance on Pakistani pilgrims, business delegations and their links in India